



management and human rights, acknowledges: "Winning the peace is going to be as challenging for us."

That would mean not only ensuring the rehabilitation of the displaced Tamils but also, as Indian officials told Sri Lanka, "addressing the root causes of the conflict". Tensions are expected to rise once the Sri Lankan Army sets up garrisons to guard the newly captured LTTE areas. With the Tamils finding hardly any representation in the army, it would lead to suspicions and unrest if such a major contingent of Sinhalese with guns becomes a permanent presence in these areas. That Rajapakse did not come out with a formula for greater devolution of powers to the Tamils before war ended is considered a mistake. Given the air of triumphalism that prevails among the Sinhalese, Rajapakse may find it hard to push for any major concessions for the Tamils. Countries like India are pushing him to implement the 13th Amendment that enshrined the Indo-Sri Lankan Accord and gave devolution of powers to the provinces. These have proved some what unsatisfactory in most of the other provinces because not only are they heavily de-

pendent on the Central Government for funds but Colombo too has control over all law and order issues. Already Pillayan, the new chief minister of the Eastern Province who defected from the LTTE, is complaining about being hemmed in and wanting true devolution of powers.

Rajapakse's assertion of "home-grown" solutions has had the international community, including India, raise its eyebrows in concern. The President wants to first hold elections in the Northern Province but finding credible alternative Tamil leaders is a tough task. Most of them are considered as quislings to the cause. There is also talk of Rajapakse going in for a presidential poll later this year which under the Sri Lankan Constitution would allow him to stay on till 2017 if he wants too.

Since his party runs a coalition government having had to poach from others to keep its majority, he would push for an early dissolution of Parliament too and hope that his widespread popularity would ensure adequate seats. But this would take almost a year, by which time the plight of the Tamils and their sense of alienation would only get worse. The economy too is in a shambles and in urgent need of investments. In the past, the Government used the war as an excuse for poor performance. Now it has none. Military victory has come at a high cost. Now the Government has to find ways to fund, not only rehabilitation of the refugees but also economic growth too.

Rajapakse's advantage is that he has proven his leadership and is wildly popular. He has the clout to persuade the Sinhalese and make a grand gesture to the Tamils and their demands. The President knows that he has to unify the two communities and end years of distrust. Otherwise there may be a revival of militancy and another Prabhakaran could be born. Unlike most war presidents, Rajapakse has the opportunity to win the peace as well. The title of peace president is his for the asking and doing. ■



RAJAPAKSE NOW HAS TO WIN THE PEACE

A. India must help us rebuild Sri Lanka. It is our immediate neighbour and it has an obligation to do this.

Q. Since China sold you arms for the war, India is concerned with your growing closeness with it?

A. China is our friend like many others—we bought arms where we could procure them from. India shouldn't worry. We are not only friends with India but we have a relationship with it. India must be large-hearted. I have said before that we would never allow any other country to use our soil to carry out activities against India.

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